Thus, among the BRICS countries, Brazil, South Africa and India are economies that demonstrate the tendencies that Marini examined on the basis of the sub-imperialist category. It is not possible to characterise China as sub-imperialist but rather as a *sui generis* imperialism of a new kind, even supplanting the United States and the European Union as the principal market for Latin American exports and as the primary investor in the region. Russia, in turn, is also not a sub-imperialist socio-economic formation but an ancient empire that until 1917 participated in inter-imperialist competition and contradictions when capitalism had reached its highest stage. The restoration of Russian capitalism with the fall of the Soviet Union reinstated it in the concert of imperialist powers. However, the comparison of the context and the nature of each of the BRICS' ascent to sub-imperialism or imperialism and their exercise of power is the theme of another essay. For now, we will underline that neither China nor Russia partakes in dependent capitalism but Brazil, South Africa and India do.

With this we are not suggesting that there are no interests and common ties among the BRICS members, among the states, classes and fractions of classes to which they respond. Nevertheless, theory and concrete social reality suggest to us a set of necessary problematisations, at the risk of obscuring global economic and political relationships and the real and present configuration of imperialist relations in which the internal contradictions and new forms of antagonistic cooperation between the dominant and subordinate links in the imperialist chain are balanced.

Concerning Brazil, we can draw attention to old and new capitalist trusts increasing their businesses in the last 15 years with BNDES financial support and share offerings (merging banking with industrial capital) that absorb neighbouring countries' wealth, just as has happened with the Vale and Votorantim mining companies, the Marfrig and JBS Friboi meat companies, Petrobras, the Odebrecht and OAS construction companies, the Gerdau group and so on. The sub-imperialist Mercosur contrasts with the large imperialist ALCA. So, too, Unasul, when it reduces itself to a forum for IIRSA implementation, plays the role that imperialism reserves for us in the international division of labour in the name of regional integration, with the difference that it seek its own sphere of influence and the relative autonomy for a dependent bourgeoisie in terms of an antagonistic cooperation with imperialist centres and at a cost for its brother neighbouring countries. Substituting China for the United States or the European Union as the principal market for exports in no way alters imperialist logic, in our view; it still plants its roots in our societies and continues to despoil the peoples of the continent with the active participation of the Brazilian governments of